

Vitruvius

Marcus Vitruvius Pollio (c.75–c.15 BCE) was a Roman architect, civil and military engineer who became known for his work *De Architectura*, or *The Ten Books on Architecture*. As the only surviving major work on architecture from classical antiquity, *De Architectura* is an important source of modern knowledge about Roman building methods, as well as planning and design. It had a huge influence on the artists and architects of the Renaissance, and for centuries influenced major buildings around the world.

Vitruvius asserted that a structure must exhibit the three qualities of *firmitas, utilitas et venustas* – firmness, commodity and delight. In other words, the ideal building is sturdy, useful and beautiful. Discussions on dimensions and ratios culminated in Vitruvius rationalizing the proportions of the human body. This ‘Vitruvian Man’ was later drawn by Leonardo da Vinci (1452–1519) as a figure within a circle and a square, the fundamental geometric shapes of the cosmic order.

MARCUS VITRUVIUS ROMAN.



Architectus antiquus Cæs. Augusti.